FREE GUIDE FOR SERVICE BUSINESS OWNERS

The Run-Without-You Guide

The 25-point checklist that tells you whether your business runs on systems or runs on you, and the 90-day order for fixing it.

For owners of established service businesses with roughly 5 to 25 employees.

BUSINESS PLANS PLUS
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Why this guide exists

Most service businesses between 5 and 25 employees have the same hidden org chart: every road leads back to the owner. You quote the work, chase the invoices, answer the team's questions, smooth over the client complaints, and remember every detail nobody wrote down.

That works at $200K. It breaks somewhere between $500K and $1M, because the owner runs out of hours before the business runs out of opportunity.

This is the checklist we use when we pressure-test a business's operations. Work through the 5 pillars. Every unchecked box is a place where the business depends on your memory instead of a system.

How to use it: check what's true today, not what you plan to fix. Count your checks at the end and use the 90-day plan to close the biggest gaps first.

1

Process

Does the work run without your memory?

- [ ] **Every client or job has documented scope and standards.** What's included, what's not, what good looks like. Not in your head, not in a text thread.
- [ ] **Your team follows checklists, not verbal instructions.** A new hire can deliver your standard without calling you.
- [ ] **Account and job details are written down.** Access info, preferences, history, special requests. If your best person quit tomorrow, nothing leaves with them.
- [ ] **Quality gets checked on a schedule, against a standard.** Someone other than you reviews the work on a set cadence.
- [ ] **New hires follow a written onboarding path.** Day 1, week 1, first 30 days. Training happens the same way every time, whether or not you're there.

> **The test:** could a competent operations lead run next week using only what's written down?

2

Sales Follow-Up

Do leads survive a busy week?

- [ ] **Every lead lands in one system.** Referrals, website requests, calls, walk-ins. One list, not sticky notes plus a spreadsheet plus your inbox.
- [ ] **Every quote has an automatic follow-up.** Most service work is won in the follow-up. If a proposal goes quiet for 5 days, something (not someone's memory) nudges it.
- [ ] **You know your pipeline number.** How many open opportunities, what they're worth, and what's stalled, without asking anyone.
- [ ] **Lost deals get a reason code.** Price, timing, went with someone else, no response. You can't fix a close rate you can't see.
- [ ] **Renewals and repeat business are calendared.** Contract anniversaries and reorder windows live in a system that reminds you early.

> **The test:** if you took two weeks off during your busiest season, would any deal die of neglect?

3

Your Front Door

Does your business sell while you sleep?

- [ ] **Your website makes the next step obvious.** A prospect landing at 9 PM can request a quote or book a call in under a minute.
- [ ] **Requests get an instant response.** Automatic confirmation immediately, human follow-up within one business day. Speed wins more deals than price does.
- [ ] **Your proof is visible.** Photos of real work, testimonials from real clients. Buyers of services are buying reliability, and reliability needs evidence.
- [ ] **You show up when someone searches your name.** Google Business Profile claimed, current, with reviews you actually ask for.
- [ ] **Your services are findable without a phone call.** If it's not listed, you're not considered for it.

> **The test:** does your website book work, or is it a brochure?

4

Automation

Is the repetitive admin off your plate?

- ☐ **Scheduling lives in software, not your head.** The team sees their schedule without texting you. Changes propagate without a phone tree.
- ☐ **Invoices go out on time without you.** Recurring work bills automatically. One-time jobs invoice within 48 hours of completion.
- ☐ **Late payments chase themselves.** Reminders at 7, 14, and 30 days fire automatically. You get pulled in at the escalation point, not the first nudge.
- ☐ **Time and job data flow to payroll and reporting** without you transcribing anything, so you can see labor by job.
- ☐ **Supplies and materials reorder on a trigger, not a panic.**

> **The test:** how many hours did you spend last week on admin a $25/hr coordinator or a $50/mo tool could own?

5

Financial Clarity

Do you know your numbers cold?

- ☐ **You know margin by job or client.** Revenue minus labor and materials, per engagement. Most service businesses have 2-3 accounts quietly losing money.
- ☐ **Labor percentage is watched monthly.** Labor is usually the biggest cost. A few points of drift is a profit crisis you want to see in week 2, not at tax time.
- ☐ **You review a simple monthly scorecard.** Revenue, margin, new leads, win rate, receivables past 30 days. One page, every month, same format.
- ☐ **Pricing is a formula, not a feeling.** Your real costs, your target margin. Price protection comes from adjusting scope, not dropping rate.
- ☐ **Cash flow is projected, not discovered.** You know what's landing and due over the next 60 days. Payroll never depends on which client pays first.

> **The test:** could you say, right now, which client is your least profitable and by how much?

Your score

Count your checked boxes.

Checks	What it means
20-25	You've built a real operating system. Protect it, optimize it, and grow into it.
12-19	Solid foundation with real gaps. The unchecked boxes are pulling you back into the day-to-day. Most owners here can close the biggest gaps in one focused quarter.
0-11	The business runs on you. That's normal, it's how everyone starts, and it's the most fixable problem in business. Start with the 90-day plan below.

The 90-day fix-it order

Don't fix everything at once. This order produces the fastest relief:

Days 1-30: Stop the revenue leaks.

Get every lead into one system and put automatic follow-up on every quote. This turns work you already did (quoting) into money.

Days 31-60: Get the work out of your head.

Documented scope for your top 5 clients, team checklists, account notes. Start with the accounts that would hurt most to lose.

Days 61-90: Turn on the numbers.

Margin by job, labor percentage monthly, one-page scorecard. Ten minutes a month on the right page beats a shoebox of good intentions.

Automation and website improvements slot in behind these three. They matter, but follow-up, process, and numbers are what let you finally take that vacation.

When you want help

Business Plans Plus builds the operating system behind growth-stage service businesses: the CRM and follow-up engine, the documented processes, the automation, and the financial visibility. Installed and working, not just recommended.

The fastest starting point is a Business Systems Audit. In 1-2 weeks you get a written bottleneck analysis, a prioritized roadmap, and 1-2 quick wins you keep no matter what. The audit fee is credited in full toward a full build within 30 days. Start at **buildwithbpp.com**.

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